



SPRA DAS

was sworn in, party chief Rajnath Singh himself picked up the phone and wooed the Shiv Sena back to the saffron fold. Battered, BJP is taking small comfort in the fact that at the last minute it managed to create a division within the Third Front and got AIADMK, AGP and INLD to vote for its candidate. "Look at it conversely. We broke the Third Front," says party spokesman Ravi Shankar Prasad.

Underneath this veneer of calm, there is a feeling of discontent. BJP leaders recall how the party had supported Mamata Banerjee's campaign against CPI(M) in Singur. "Both L.K. Advani and Sushma Swaraj went to Singur as part

VICTORY MARCH: Congress is riding high on Patil's election

of a fact-finding team. Yet when it was our turn, Mamata did not support us," says a party general secretary somewhat glumly. The only allies that unconditionally supported Shekhawat are those supported by BJP in state coalition governments, such as BJP, Akali Dal and JD(U). However, the Janata Dal (S), with whom BJP has an alliance in Karnataka, abstained from the vote.

Clearly, Rajnath needs to update the direct dial on his telephone. Delegating allies management is not yielding the desired results. To add to the confusion,

BJP is also not quite sure of Shekhawat's plans. The former vice-president has indicated that he is not ready to retire just yet.

It has certainly been a tough election for BJP. Even those in the NDA who supported Shekhawat's candidature have not taken kindly to the shrillness of BJP's attack on Patil. JD(U) chief Sharad Yadav told BJP spokesman Prakash Javadekar that he was not very happy with the tone of the campaign. "The entire presidential campaign was limited to a certain group and was not an all-party affair," explains a BJP vice-president. Spearheading the attack was Advani. The leader of the Opposition unleashed a letter campaign to the Election Commission (EC) in an attempt to weaken the UPA's case for Patil. That almost all his requests were turned down by the EC only further damaged BJP's credibility.

In contrast, Rajnath's silence told its own tale. The division within the party was evident. The location for the launch of a 'smear Pratibha' website was not the BJP office, but former party president and Advani loyalist Venkaiah Naidu's residence. The BJP chief was careful to maintain a safe distance from the slew of allegations against Patil. Unlike Advani and company, neither Atal Bihari Vajpayee nor Rajnath attacked the UPA candidate. With Assembly elections in Gujarat due at the end of the year, Rajnath is trying not to play camp politics. Not only did he take swift action against the rebel MLAs (those who voted against Shekhawat belong to Narendra Modi-baiter Keshubhai Patel's camp), he also gave party General Secretary Arun Jaitley, a Modi confidante, charge of the elections in Gujarat.

Post presidential polls, BJP's internal politics has become interesting again. Some in the party are taking Advani's active role in the campaign as an indication that he wants to be more than just the party patriarch. Advani is adamant that while BJP may have lost the battle of numbers, it has won the war of public perception. According to him, not only did Patil's choice highlight the "chaotic" decision-making within the ruling alliance, but it also "provoked all the right thinking people

BJP questioned SONIA'S ABILITY to make the right choice. To prove it wrong, CONGRESS MANAGERS worked overtime.